Infiltration Techniques for Couples

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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Infiltration Techniques for Couples

by Fuhadeza

Summary

Bringing magic back to the universe goes swimmingly until it doesn't. When one planet turns out suspiciously anti-magic, Catra comes up with a perfect, sure-to-work, definitely-won't-cause-any-issues plan to investigate.

Written for the She-Ra Anniversary Big Bang - check out the accompanying art by kladderier here!

Notes

this is my fic for the She-Ra anniversary Big Bang! this idea has been bouncing around in my head for ages, and I finally had the opportunity to do something with it.

Chapter 1

By the fifth planet, their reputation was beginning to precede them.

'Incoming transmission,' Bow said as Darla settled into a comfortable orbit around Charobia. 'That was quick. They must have some pretty good orbital detection tech.'

'Send them the welcome video,' Glimmer said.

After the third time she and Adora had found themselves explaining their mission to a packed room of sceptical aliens, it occurred to her that everything would go much faster if they could skip that part. They'd spent the travel time to planet number four composing *Who We Are And Why We Want To Bring Magic To Your Planet*. Number four went flawlessly. A new record.

'I don't think that's going to be necessary.'

Glimmer frowned. Bow's voice had ratcheted up ever so slightly. 'What's wrong?'

'They already know who we are. This message is addressed to Queen Glimmer of Etheria, She-Ra, Master Technologist Bow—' Bow broke off. 'Technologist? That's a new one. And since when were you Queen of all Etheria?'

'Well, technically, I *am* queen and I *am* of Etheria.'

Bow gave her a look.

'Kidding! They're probably just confused. Or flattering me. What about Catra?'

'They don't mention Catra.'

'Oh, she's gonna *love* that.'

‘*Maybe*,’ Bow said, with the aggrieved tone of someone who had put his whole heart into directing a short informational video, ‘she shouldn’t have refused to be in the film.’

Glimmer stretched as best she could in the awkward angles of the captain’s chair. ‘I’ll get Adora. She should hear what they have to say.’

Darla was a far cry from the sterile First Ones’ vessel she’d once been. Her corridors were carpeted with intricately patterned rugs —courtesy of Bright Moon’s many, many disused guest rooms— and her doorways were hung with curtains for privacy. There was a proper pantry, stocked with things other than space travel rations, and the walls were decorated with art from the first four worlds they’d visited. Once, Darla had been a way to get from place to place. Now, she was a home.

Glimmer paused outside the room Adora shared with Catra. She could see them through a gap in the curtains, curled up together on the large mattress that occupied one corner. Catra’s head was tucked under Adora’s, tail twitching lightly in her sleep. Glimmer sighed. For all the *friendly sparring* she and Catra engaged in, the sight of her peaceful and happy with Adora never failed to lift Glimmer’s spirits. They were a sort of symbol. Proof that anything broken could be fixed, with the right will.

‘Adora?’ she called, without stepping into the room proper. Past experience had taught her that Catra was particular about boundaries and thresholds.

Adora’s eyes flickered open almost immediately. Beside her, Catra made a noise of protest.

‘Sorry,’ Glimmer said. ‘But the Charobians noticed us faster than Bow expected. They’ve already got in touch.’

‘Five minutes,’ Adora said, already reaching for fresh clothing.

‘Ten minutes,’ Catra said, the hint of a purr in her voice, and pulled Adora back down.

*

Fifteen minutes later, Catra said, '*What?* What about me?'

'Called it,' Glimmer said, without looking up from one of Darla's control panels and therefore entirely missing the withering glare Catra sent her way.

'They must have seen the video,' Bow added. 'The video you're not in.'

Catra shifted the glare to Bow. Then she looked at Adora, who gave her a *you know I'll always have your back but also they're kind of right* shrug.

'Whatever.' Catra directed her ire at the planet hanging above them instead. It was a beautiful thing, even by the standards of the rest of the universe, all orange and purple mottled with the whites of clouds. She stuck her tongue out at it. 'Are we gonna listen to this message or what?'

Bow pressed a few buttons on the control panel. 'Here we go.'

A person appeared in the air in front of him. He jumped back with a squawk.

'Hello,' the person said. 'Please do not be alarmed. This is an advanced hologram system.'

If Catra squinted, she could just about make out a haze around the edges; otherwise the woman looked completely solid. It was nothing like the holograms she was used to.

'I am Consul Rovin,' the woman said. 'I would like to invite Queen Glimmer, Bow, and She-Ra to Charobia to discuss the purpose of your visit. Attached to this message are a set of landing co-ordinates. When you are ready to meet, follow them to the surface. Someone will be waiting.'

And she blinked out of existence.

‘Yes!’ Glimmer said from the captain’s chair. ‘It’s working! See? All we have to do is show up! I knew the video was a good idea.’

‘I don’t know,’ Catra said sourly. ‘Something doesn’t feel right.’

‘You’re just sulking because you’re not invited.’

‘I am *not* sulk—’

Adora’s arms around her waist shut her up. ‘No, you’re definitely sulking.’ She kissed the tip of Catra’s left ear, making it twitch.

‘What I don’t get,’ Bow said in his too-loud, *I am ignoring your blatant canoodling* voice, ‘is how Darla’s systems were able to play that hologram.’

‘Who cares!’ Glimmer got up and joined him at the comms panel. ‘I mean, you can ask them when we land. Seems like they’re pretty technologically advanced.’ She winked at Bow, took his hand in hers. ‘Imagine how jealous Entrapta will be when we get back.’

(‘Ooh, look, they’re holding hands,’ Catra said. ‘We’ll have them making out in the supply closet in no time.’

Glimmer made a rude gesture behind her back.)

‘Yeah,’ Bow said, warming quickly to his theme. ‘Yeah! You guys can teach them about magic, and maybe they’ll teach me about their tech!’ His hands flew over the controls. ‘I’m taking us down.’

The descent was Catra’s least favourite part.

Darla screamed through the atmosphere, the ground taking on sudden, terrifying texture, the pretty colours making themselves known as individual trees and rock formations and other features of the landscape one might crash a spaceship into. Bow had got better at piloting in the year they’d spent in space, which only meant that he never *actually* hit anything. The breakneck landing

speed was, as far as anyone could tell, a deliberate feature of Darla's design.

And then—'*Wow*,' Adora breathed. The word raised goosebumps on the back of Catra's neck, and she was forced to agree with Adora's assessment.

The city rising before them was unlike anything she'd ever seen. The other planets—some of which had been bastions of rebellion for centuries, others liberated only with Prime's death—had all been ex-Horde. It was obvious from their technology, if nothing else. Charobia was different. The buildings Bow was now navigating carefully between were clearly based on neither Horde nor First Ones principles. They—*drifted* was the word, floating above the ground like jellyfish in the shallow seas around Salineas. Catra couldn't tell what held them up. Some were translucent, others open to the elements entirely. Below, more solid-looking neighbourhoods formed a carpet of scintillating curve.

The four of them were very, very far from home.

Bow brought Darla down on a landing pad halfway up one of the larger buildings. The engines shut off. There were already people waiting outside.

Adora squeezed Catra's hand. 'It's okay,' she murmured in her ear.

'Obviously,' Catra said, disentangling herself. 'Don't get yourselves in trouble, okay? I'm tired. I don't want to have to come rescue you.'

'You're not coming?' Glimmer asked.

'I wasn't invited, remember?'

'*Really*, Catra? I'm sure they wouldn't—'

Adora raised a hand, cutting Glimmer off. 'You sure?' she said, quiet enough that only Catra could hear.

‘Yeah.’

‘I can stay, if you want.’

‘It’s fine.’ Catra ducked her head. There was still something—*embarrassing*, about the way Adora would prioritise her even above something as important as this. ‘I just need some time to myself.’

‘Okay.’

Adora’s smile settled the anxiety in Catra’s stomach. Her kiss lingered on Catra’s lips long after she left the ship with Bow and Glimmer.

*

Bow was used to a certain routine on each new planet. Whether the locals were openly awe-struck or not, gracious or sceptical, the underlying feeling was the same: everyone had heard, by now, the basics of what had happened on Etheria; everyone knew that history had been made, and Bow and his friends had been the makers, even if the exact details had been lost along the way.

This time around it was different.

The Charobians looked more or less like humans on Etheria. Taller, maybe, if the welcoming party of three was representative; a little more robustly built. But Etheria itself was home to so many different kinds of people that it was easy to forget that these were, technically, aliens.

‘Hello,’ one of them said. ‘Please follow us.’

That was it. No introductions. No fawning. They could equally have been honoured guests or prisoners en route to a particularly polite block of cells. Bow glanced at Glimmer. Her mouth was half-open, as if she’d been expecting to make a speech, but she merely shrugged and did as their escort asked.

Bow fell in next to her. He could sense Adora behind them, bringing up the rear with the twitchy, alert presence she hadn't entirely unlearned yet, like someone still convinced it was her job to protect everyone else.

'Something's off, right?' he said, low enough that their escorts wouldn't hear.

'I think so,' Glimmer replied. 'It's like they're… not interested in us?'

Bow waited a beat, then realised Catra wasn't with them and wouldn't be interjecting with a deadpan *The horror.* 'That's okay,' he said brightly. 'They won't be able to resist our charm in person. Especially now that Catra's not with us.'

Glimmer snorted. 'Give her some credit. She's charming when she wants to be. Just not in a… diplomatic way.'

Bow laughed and determined not to be anxious until he had a good reason. Charobia was beautiful, after all: ethereal in a way even Etheria wasn't. Whatever technology kept the buildings afloat, high above the windswept, purple-red grass, was completely invisible, as if it were a perfectly natural thing for buildings to ignore the pull of gravity. Maybe, he thought, they already *had* magic on Charobia. That wasn't impossible. Maybe that's why their reaction to the video wasn't as dramatic as it had been on the previous planet.

Glimmer's hand brushed his, deniably. Bow hooked his little finger around hers.

He wasn't sure why they found themselves so shy about being openly affectionate in public. It had something to do with the long years of their friendship—a sense that something had changed, but neither could tell *what*. It made sense, to go back to square one and rediscover what it meant to be together, not as friends but as a couple. That was what he told himself, no matter how much Catra—who had quickly gone the exact opposite direction

with Adora, as if determined to make up for three years of lost time, and possibly a few years more on top; Bow had frankly given up trying to understand what exactly their relationship had been in the Horde—teased him for it.

Still—Glimmer's touch, light though it was, remained a steady presence as they passed into the cavernous interior of one of the buildings.

*

In the last year, Adora had seen enough conference rooms, council chambers, and other places important people liked to gather to last her a decade. It almost made her miss the council room in Bright Moon. At least that was a familiar place. Friendly, almost.

The Charobian version was relatively small, which was a point in its favour, with translucent walls, which very much was not. There was a constant stream of people going by outside, half-seen through the walls like shadows, and they were making her jumpy. The furniture, too, had a strange pearlescent, see-through quality to it. Combined with the knowledge that the building was *floating*, it made her worry the whole thing was going to collapse like a soap bubble.

'Welcome to Charobia!'

Adora focused on the woman who had just entered the room. It was the woman from the hologram, she was pretty sure, but her memory for faces was better than her memory for names. It started with an M. Catra would probably have remembered.

'I am Consul Rovin. I hope your journey here was pleasant.'

Adora suppressed a yawn. Glimmer and Bow would handle the small-talk. She'd hang back and watch. That was Catra's job, usually, but how hard could it be? Rovin was a tall woman, on a scale with Huntara but dressed in what was clearly a formal style, all bright blocks of colours hanging gracefully from her body like a

—a set of curtains. The clothing was at odds with Rovin's bare, muscled forearms. Behind her, a man hung back, shorter and more slender. He had the air of a pilot fish to Rovin's shark.

'This is Belen, our Keeper of the Past. We are here to represent Charobia. Will you take a seat?'

Adora perked up. This sounded like getting down to business. Usually there was more excruciating small-talk. The three of them sat down, Glimmer in the middle flanked by Bow and Adora.

Rovin beamed at them across the table. 'We thank you for having travelled so far,' she said. 'You are of course welcome on our planet as guests. We've heard of your exploits on Etheria, and we acknowledge the universe owes you a great debt. If you wish, we can provide accommodation for the duration of your stay.'

'Thank you,' Glimmer said guardedly, 'but we're happy on our ship.'

Rovin inclined her head. 'Then I will get to the heart of the matter. We respectfully decline your offer.'

Adora stared at her. 'What?'

'Your video laid it out quite clearly. We have decided that we do not require your help.'

'Respectfully,' Glimmer began, but Adora got there first: 'But you haven't even seen what magic could do for you! Etheria has been totally transformed since I got rid of Prime—'

'Ah. Yes. You are the one known as She-Ra?'

'Yes,' Adora said, only a beat late. It was a good thing, she reflected, that Catra wasn't here. She hated it when people looked at Adora and saw She-Ra.

'We are grateful for all you have done,' Rovin repeated, 'but we do not believe your help is necessary on Charobia.'

‘Won’t you at least let me *show* you,’ Adora said, already raising her arm, visualising the sword appearing in her hand—

‘*Stop*.’

The lights overhead flickered. Guiltily, Adora stopped, the white glow of She-Ra fading almost before it had appeared.

Belen—the Keeper of the Past, Rovin had called him?—was glaring at her. ‘We have told you we do not want magic here. Why do you insist on using it?’

Adora opened her mouth. Next to her, she could sense Glimmer revving up, too, but before either of them could say anything, Bow interrupted in the loud, slightly-too-stressed tone he adopted whenever Adora or Catra or Glimmer grew too belligerent.

‘Consul! I’ve never seen anything *like* your technology before. It’s *very impressive*. Is it based on First Ones tech? I’d *love* to get the chance to examine some of it in person.’

Rovin smiled. ‘Of course—you are the technologist? We would be happy to show you around some of our facilities while you’re on-planet. I’m not an expert myself, but Belen has considerable knowledge in the field. I’m told some of our innovations are unique throughout the universe.’

Glimmer was back on her poise, smiling and gracious. ‘That would be *fascinating,*’ she said, glancing sideways at Adora as if making sure they were on the same, non-belligerent page. ‘But if you’ll excuse us, I think we’d best return to our ship. Perhaps we can arrange something for later this week?’

The moment they were out of earshot, goodbyes said and on their way back to Darla, Glimmer said, ‘They’re hiding something.’

Bow groaned. ‘Just because they turned you down doesn’t mean they’re hiding something.’

‘No,’ Adora said, ‘I think Glimmer’s right. Did you see the way that Keeper of the Past guy freaked out when I tried to transform into She-Ra? It’s like he was totally unbothered and then suddenly, boom! Panic! Something weird is going on. Why would they not want magic?’

‘The only person we know who hated magic,’ Glimmer said darkly, ‘was Horde Prime.’

‘Okay, okay, *slow down*,’ Bow said. ‘Disliking magic doesn’t make them evil! Catra isn’t a huge fan of magic either!’

Glimmer’s fists were clenched. Adora could practically see her struggling to admit Bow was right. For all that Adora privately suspected he was wrong, she didn’t think it was the right time to argue about it. They were tired. Grumpy. Nothing good would come of it.

‘Well,’ she said, just a little cocky, ‘she’s actually a big fan of *certain kinds of magic*, if you know what I mean.’

‘I have absolutely no idea what you mean,’ Glimmer said, deadpan, but she was fighting back laughter. ‘I know, I know. I just thought—we figured it out! It would be easy from now on! And now… this. I guess—ugh, this sounds so self-absorbed, but I guess I got used to being treated like the saviours of the universe.’

‘They *were* impressed by that,’ Bow pointed out. ‘Who knows? Maybe we can learn all about their technology. That would be a good trade, wouldn’t it?’

‘Yeah.’ Glimmer smiled. ‘Yeah, it would.’

*

It took Catra an hour to work out what was bothering her.

She got back into bed to begin with, lying on her back in the twisted sheets, staring at the ceiling and listening to the soft hum

of Darla's stand-by systems; but that reminded her too much of the old days, of sleepless nights punctuated by anxiety dreams. She sighed, sat up. Traced her claws through the grooves down by eye-level, where she and Adora had, one giggly, tipsy night, carved the letters *C + A* like they were kids again.

That wasn't what was bothering her. When she looked at anything but the ceiling, her room—hers and Adora's—was nothing like the grim Force Captain's quarters back in the Fright Zone. Every inch of it was covered in the evidence of their relationship. Trinkets they'd picked up on other planets; gifts they'd received, together, as a couple.

Catra had learnt how to deal with her emotions over the years, and it wasn't going to happen in the safe, comforting environs of the ship that had become her home.

The streets of Charobia were not so much streets as everything in between: bridges arcing elegantly over a plummet to the planet surface, stairways curled around the sides of buildings floating on the breeze or disappearing down to parts of the city she couldn't make out. Catra couldn't imagine what had led to this city in the sky. The whole edifice looked like it would come apart if she so much as grazed it with her claws. What was wrong with the surface?

Instinct took her downwards. The fluted columns of the upper city, like Bright Moon rendered in tissue paper, gave way to buildings built in and on top of giant mushrooms. In between, smaller pods flitted like dandelions—vehicles or dwellings, she couldn't tell which. Perhaps both. Catra was used to living on a ship by now. Why shouldn't the Charobians do likewise? For all the elegance above, this part of the city was more familiar. She'd seen its like, in the Crimson Waste, in the ports that served Salineas, and on each of the planets they'd visited so far: somewhere grounded—literally, in this case, compared to the floating wonders above—for people to rub shoulders, eat together, buy and sell things; even if the buying and selling seemed marginally more legal on Charobia than it was in those other

places. Here, the marketplace took the form of a platform sprouting from beneath a mushroom cup as if it was itself part of the living thing. Below, she could see other platforms, spiralling down the stem for almost half its height.

Catra relaxed.

The people around her were a mix, Charobians and half a dozen other species, known and unknown. She fit right in. That was what had been bothering her, up above. Adora and Glimmer stood out wherever they went, She-Ra and the Queen—but when Catra stood out, she wanted it to be on her own terms. It was why she'd passed on Bow's video. Sometimes anonymity was a boon.

Even if it did rankle that the Charobians hadn't issued her an invitation.

'—She-Ra poisoned her world with magic, and now she wants to do the same to us!'

Well. At least she'd had a few minutes of peace.

The voice came from the far end of the platform, where a man stood by the railing, heedless of the drop behind him. He wasn't Charobian, Catra was pretty sure, but he was still taller than the average Etherian, and he'd made himself taller still with a box emblazoned *CosmiClean, Purveyors of Soap and Artisanal Bath Salts*. There was a small crowd gathered around him.

Catra sighed and began to push her way through.

'People of Charobia, you are wise to the ways of magic. For centuries you have flourished without it, but now outside forces are on the move, selling lies and their own selfish agenda! Stand against them, my friends—and with us! With the Inheritors of Hope. We've seen other worlds fall to the scourge of magic. Together, we can make sure that doesn't happen to you.'

Catra frowned. Whoever this asshole was, he couldn't possibly have had time since Darla arrived to compose his speech, collect

his soapbox, and—print *flyers?* The poster the man was brandishing depicted Adora as She-Ra, drawn by someone who had clearly never seen her in person and had zero appreciation for how fucking attractive she was. Catra almost laughed, but she didn't need to know how Charobian numbers or currency worked to know that the bounty on the poster was breathtakingly high. The crowd—until now, only idly interested—leaned in, energised.

'For the criminal known as She-Ra, our brave leader is willing to offer a previously unheard-of bounty!' The man stepped down from his box, opened it, and pulled out a pile of posters, identical to the one he'd displayed. 'Take a flyer—show all your friends—spread the word! She-Ra is dangerous. Keep her out of Charobia!'

The people around Catra were giving her strange looks. She forced herself to relax, to uncurl her lips, but inside the indignation mounted. Adora wasn't a criminal. She was only trying to help. If anything, there should be a price on Catra's head. *No one* was allowed to put a price on Adora's head, except for maybe Catra. And *absolutely* no one was allowed to *capture* Adora, except for maybe—

A smile replaced the snarl on her face, wide and toothy and just as effective at making people get out of her way. She sauntered up to the *Inheritor of Hope*, and wasn't that a stupid name, plucked a pile of bounty posters from his hand before he could so much as say hello, and disappeared back into the crowd.

These people, whoever they were, wanted Adora? Catra would teach them to be careful what they wished for.

*

When Bow stepped onto the bridge, Catra was lounging in the captain's chair, folding and unfolding a piece of paper.

'What took you so long?' she said, smirking. 'I thought the whole video thing was meant to make things go faster.'

There were times when Catra's obstinance got on Bow's nerves, but this time it made him smile. It's not that he *really* cared about the welcome video. Catra had every right not to be in it. It had been fun, and it was a shame she'd missed out on that, but maybe the enjoyment she got out of poking fun at him for it was worth it, in the end. She was certainly in a better mood.

'It did. But then we went for a walk.'

Catra raised her eyebrows. 'So, what, we're all set here? On this planet?'

'Not—exactly.' Bow flashed what he hoped was a *let's wait for Glimmer to elaborate on that* smile. 'But hey, did you know some of the buildings are on top of giant *mushrooms*?'

'Yep.'

'I thought all the buildings floated, but no, maybe that's just the fancy ones, and I have no idea how the stems can support all that weight, there must be some tech in them somewhere—' Bow cut himself. 'Wait, really? You went for a walk too?'

'Did you know there's stuff under the caps, too?'

'*Really*? How? Is it attached?'

'To the stem, I think. I can take you. I found a market. Charming place, except for the—' Catra paused. Her ears twitched. She snorted. 'Meeting didn't go well, huh?'

Bow opened his mouth to say *What?*, but a moment later his human ears caught up and he winced.

'—cannot *believe* they said no! Without even *listening* to us first! I think we should—'

'Ah,' he said. The mushroom-themed walk with Catra would have to wait. 'I guess she's not over it yet. Glimmer,' he added, loud

enough to be heard in the corridor outside, 'I thought we were going to give them the benefit of the doubt?'

'I *am* giving them the benefit of the doubt,' Glimmer said, and to her credit she sounded only a little insincere. 'That's why I waited until we were back on the ship to start complaining.'

'I swear I wasn't encouraging her,' Adora said, entering behind Glimmer. 'But they *could* have at least let me do my thing—' She caught sight of Catra, and the way her expression brightened immediately made Bow smile, even if he couldn't quite identify the twinge he felt when Catra craned her neck backwards for an upside-down, over-the-armrest kiss.

'Let me guess,' Catra said, hooking one finger casually around Adora's belt. 'They told you thanks very much but we're not interested in magic, end of meeting?'

'Yes. And—' Glimmer sighed. 'I know, I know, we have no reason to think there's anything suspicious going on.' Bow gave her a thumbs up. She smiled crookedly. 'But it just rubs me the wrong way, you know?'

'I know,' Bow said. 'And I'm sure they'll be more forthcoming the longer we spend here, right? Maybe they think they don't need magic because of their technology. We can think of it as a vacation, maybe! Relax, see the sights—'

'Bow,' Catra said, 'I'm pretty sure there's something suspicious going on.'

Bow stared at her. It was difficult not to feel betrayed. Catra, of all people, should have had his back on this. 'What?'

Catra untangled herself, first from Adora, then from the chair, and unfolded the paper in her hands. 'Hey, Adora,' she said. 'How's it feel being Charobia's public enemy number one?'

Bow stared at the image of She-Ra, willing it to make sense. Why would there be a bounty on She-Ra? Adora hadn't done anything.

The Charobians barely seemed interested in her. Maybe it wasn't official? But they'd barely arrived. Bow clamped down on his anxiety. It wasn't helpful. They'd figure out what to do, all four of them—

'I dunno,' Adora said, squinting at the wanted poster, lips pursed. Her voice was more mischievous than anxious. 'Do you think I should offer to pose for them? It's not the best picture—'

'Hey, Catra,' Glimmer interrupted, 'where's *your* wanted poster?'

Catra bristled. 'Obviously, if I had one, the bounty would be triple Adora's. *But*, I made the very sensible decision of staying out of your video, and you're all going to be thanking me when you hear my plan—'

'*Guys*,' Bow said, fully aware his voice had gone up an octave and unable to help it. 'Can we take this *seriously?* There's a bounty! On Adora! For some reason! *Again*.'

'Wait, let's not get carried away,' Catra said, over the sound of Adora's delighted *Oh yeah!* 'The Crimson Waste barely counted—no, Adora, it did *not*, Scorpia took care of it. You weren't even on Etheria at the time.'

'True,' Adora said. 'I was too busy rescuing you from space jail.'

That stunned Catra long enough for Glimmer to get a word in. '*All right*, can we not play the *who can be more insufferably cocky* game when we're on a planet that maybe has it out for us?'

'*Thank* you,' Bow said.

'Right,' Adora said, blushing slightly. 'Sorry. What are our options?'

'Start with the obvious,' Bow said. 'We could leave.'

'The vibe I got is that these people weren't from Charobia,' Catra said, nodding at the wanted poster. 'If that's true, leaving won't solve anything.'

Privately, Bow found that a relief. Distaste for magic aside, Charobia was a fascinating place. He was looking forward to taking up their hosts on their offer of a tour. 'Do we think this has anything to do with why the Consul and her friends turned us down?'

'Of course it does!' Glimmer said, right on schedule. 'How else would these—whoever they are—'

'They call themselves the Inheritors of Hope,' Catra said helpfully.

'How else would the Inheritors of Hope know Adora was here? The Consul must have told them we were coming.'

'Maybe.' Bow frowned. 'But then why offer a bounty? They could have just arrested Adora.'

'Keeping their hands clean,' Glimmer countered. 'You know, get some bounty hunters to do their dirty work. It's how I'd do it.' She paused. 'Back me up here, Catra, this is more your area of expertise.'

Catra snorted. 'Thanks. But she's right. I think we have to assume the Inheritors are working with the Charobians.'

'It doesn't really matter,' Adora said quietly. 'Whether or not it's a coincidence, we need to investigate. If there's really a group out there that's trying to stop She-Ra—trying to stop *magic*—we need to know.'

There followed a silence, which between the four of them always meant *agreed*.

'The Consul offered to show us around,' Glimmer said thoughtfully. 'Bow and I can take her up on that, see if we can figure anything out from that angle. Catra, do you think you could find the person who gave you that poster? Or maybe—'

'Way ahead of you.' Catra plucked the wanted poster from Adora's hands and offered it to Bow, blank side up.

‘What’s this?’ Bow asked.

‘A shopping list.’

‘For what?’

‘My plan.’

Bow accepted the poster from her. He’d missed it at first, because the list was short, relegated to one corner in Catra’s surprisingly neat handwriting. ‘A video recording and playback device. A weapon—’ He frowned. ‘What kind of weapon?’

‘Something flashy. It’s mostly for show.’

Bow gave Catra a dubious look, then glanced back down at the list and spluttered. ‘A *sexy leather outfit?*’

‘I figure Glimmer can help you with that.’

‘I don’t know if you’ve noticed, but “sexy leather” is *not* Glimmer’s style.’

‘No, but it’s *my* style.’ Catra grinned. ‘So, like I said, I think she can help with that.’

Glimmer squawked a wordless protest. Catra ignored her.

‘Fine,’ Bow said, ‘I’ll bite. What’s the plan?’

Catra didn’t answer immediately. Instead, she glanced at Adora, who was still unusually quiet, staring at the wanted poster even now that she couldn’t see the image of herself—her other self—anymore. Presently, she looked up, as if she could sense Catra’s attention. It was a reaction Bow recognised intimately. He could always tell when Glimmer was looking at him, could usually guess what she wanted to say to him. It made things easy. Comfortable.

Adora nodded, once, almost imperceptibly, then again, more firmly.

Whatever wordless question had passed between them, this was apparently response enough for Catra. She turned back to Bow and Glimmer.

‘Isn’t it obvious? I’m going to collect the bounty.’

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

a few things before we start:

1. check out the awesome concept art Kladderier did for this fic! I am in love with both of the designs <3
2. thank you ForsythiaRising for naming I think every character in this chapter. bonus points if anyone can work out what they're all short for.
3. if you have time, check out some of the other Big Bang fics! :D (they're all in the collection, you can get there from the tags)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Tero was on door duty the day the bounty hunter came in.

Her brother Neto was out distributing more of the She-Ra bounty posters, but there were half a dozen other people in the front room, lounging in the big, organic-looking Charobian chairs or leaning over a game of cards, and every last one of them looked up when the door slid open.

The bounty hunter was short. She was dressed in black and red leather that hugged her body more than was practical, culminating in a curving shoulder-piece that left her upper arms bare. A Charobian style, that was, but the woman was clearly from off-planet. The ears poking out from her unruly ponytail didn't belong to a species Tero recognised. Her eyes, mismatched blue and yellow, scanned the room with dismissive amusement.

Tero wasn't falling for it. She'd seen her share of hunters dressed to the nines. Nine times out of ten, they were all leather and no steel. And besides, Boss had told her not to let anyone in.

She puffed out her chest, stepped forward, and put on her best violence-is-imminent voice. 'You lost, kitty?'

The woman's gaze landed on her. She wore a power-whip at her hip, which only confirmed Tero's impression of her. No one used a weapon that impractical if they wanted to be taken seriously.

'*Kitty?*' she said, and Tero prepared herself for the outburst; but the woman only laughed. Her voice was dark and husky like the rest of her. 'Well done. Incredible powers of observation. Next you'll tell me my eyes are different colours. Who's in charge?'

The suddenness of the question almost caught Tero off-guard. 'I am,' she said, recovering quickly, only to falter in the face of the woman's raised eyebrows. 'Right now I am. Boss is busy.'

'Not anymore,' the woman drawled. 'Fetch. I'm not wasting my time on grunts.'

Movement out of the corner of Tero's eye: Omet, slinking around the perimeter of the room with weapon in hand. Tero drew herself up. She was nearly a half foot taller than the stranger, and she wasn't about to let a spineless opportunist like Omet upstage her.

'Boss,' she repeated, slowly and clearly, 'is *busy*, and even if she wasn't, she wouldn't have anything to do with the likes of you. Now be a good girl, turn around, and go back to whatever backwater you came from before someone gets hurt.'

That was good. Condescending, tough, unyielding. No one could say she hadn't done her job.

'All right.' The woman sighed. 'I'll go back to Etheria.'

Tero's mouth fell open. The atmosphere in the room changed instantly, like bored onlookers suddenly presented with the opportunity to join the fight themselves.

'You're one of the *magic* users,' she spat, a moment before Omet exploded into action.

The woman's elbow found Omet's nose before Tero was even aware she'd moved. The *crack* of impact shuddered through the

room. Omet dropped.

‘Magic? Don’t insult me.’ The woman smiled, feral. ‘Name’s Catra, and once upon a time every princess on Etheria trembled—’

Tero gave the signal. The whole room was on their feet in an instant, charging the stranger with weapons drawn. No matter how good her reflexes, no one could stand against five-to-one odds without being overwhelmed by sheer weight—

Catra did not stand against them. She leapt impossibly high, one leg snapping out in an elegant arc entirely at odds with the sound her foot made impacting a face. Her power whip was in her hand before she hit the ground, lashing out and ensnaring two more of Tero’s people so fast the only thing left was an afterimage.

Watching her was almost beautiful. She moved like no one else Tero had ever seen, fast and lithe and with zero concern for her own safety, punctuated by the sharp, brutal reports of bodies hitting the ground.

The fight lasted thirty seconds.

‘—to hear it,’ Catra finished. If she was out of breath, she knew how to keep it hidden. Six of Tero’s best people lay on the floor, twitching. One scrambled away, desperate to put a table between him and Catra.

Six of her people, and that meant Tero was the only one left standing, and suddenly Catra was advancing on her. She walked like she fought, silent and beautiful and pregnant with the promise of violence, and Tero finally realised her mistake.

Nine times out of ten, people who dressed like Catra would compensate for their height. They’d wear heavy, extravagant boots with six-inch heels and trip over themselves the moment they had to fight. They’d make unwise decisions as soon as someone called them *short*.

Catra was barefoot.

Tero wasn't aware of backing away until she bumped up against a yielding Charobian wall. Catra stopped a foot away and reached out almost leisurely. Her hand gripped Tero by the chin and forced her to meet her gaze. Claws dug into Tero's cheeks. Catra's eyes were brighter than anyone's eyes should be. Her lips curved smile-like around impossibly sharp teeth. Tero couldn't tell if the thud of her heartbeat was fear or attraction or both.

'Now,' Catra breathed. 'I'm feeling *very* magnanimous today, so I'm going to forgive'—her other hand gestured dismissively over her shoulder—'all this, as long as you get your boss and you get her *now*, and you tell her that I've got a little present for her.' Catra let go. Tero gulped a breath. 'You've got five minutes. After that…' Catra's smile was unreadable. 'I'm taking She-Ra someplace else.'

*

Adora watched Catra dress in silence.

Catra wore all sorts of things, these days. Long, flowing tunics that hid her like a flower hiding its thorn. Formal pieces, suits and gowns and things that were both and neither, that wouldn't have looked out of place at the most exclusive ball on Etheria. Casual clothes, shorn so short they made Adora blush whenever Catra strolled out in public.

All of them looked good on her—and yet Adora never liked it quite so much as when Catra returned to her roots, her reds and blacks ripped and belted together in a combination that looked almost intentional.

That was the Catra she'd fallen in love with.

This one? This Catra was returning to a different kind of roots.

'You're staring,' Catra said. She sounded amused, teasing, satisfied, all things that made Adora's heart beat a little faster.

She tore her gaze away from the trousers Catra was pulling up over her hips. 'You look…'

'Evil, I hope.'

Adora bit her lip. 'Um. I was going to say "hot".'

Catra flashed her a smile, incongruously sweet against the black leather outlining her body. 'I know you were.'

'Why do you always have—' Adora gestured at her own chest, which unlike Catra's was sensibly covered by a high-necked white top. 'You know.'

'Because,' Catra purred, 'I know you like to look,' and there was something magnetic in her voice, in the way her new clothes creaked as she moved, and Adora leaned forward and—

'Wow*,' Glimmer said from the door, and Adora sprang away from Catra as if they'd been caught making out. 'She really did a number on you, huh. Catra, were you* trying *to give Adora a thing for femme fatales?'*

'Ew. No. I was trying to give her a thing for me.' Catra bent over, picked up the power-whip on their bed, made a show of stretching it between her outspread hands. Her tail beat a leisurely rhythm. 'You, *I was trying to give a thing for femme fatales.'*

Glimmer groaned in a way that Adora translated as a blush. 'I thought we agreed not *to talk about that. Come on. Bow's ready with the recorder on the bridge.'*

'Two minutes,' Adora said. 'We need to finish up.'

Glimmer spared them one more glance. 'I'll bet you do.' Then she was gone.

All at once Adora felt—uncertain. It was one thing to discuss the plan, to project the sort of confidence Adora had always been

excellent at faking; another thing entirely so see Catra dressed for the part, to know that in a few short hours they'd be acting like enemies again. Even if it was all fake.

'Hey,' Catra said. 'You don't have to do this.'

You *don't have to, not* we*. Catra didn't have any qualms. That was good enough for Adora.*

'No, it's okay. I'll be fine. Just need to, you know.' Adora's laugh had a nervous edge. 'Get used to, um, you. Again.'

This time, Catra didn't tease. Her hands were gloved, but like any pair of gloves Catra had ever worn, she'd ripped the fingertips off. Her touch was light and reassuring on Adora's cheek.

'It's always me,' she said quietly. 'Don't forget, okay? It's always me, no matter what I say to them. Or to you. And you're always you, and that means you can turn into a big, dumb sword lady whenever you want and come get me. See?' She ran her fingers along the stiff black shoulder-piece that framed her arms and chest. 'I even took some fashion cues from She-Ra. I figured you wouldn't mind, seeing as you stole the whole mask idea from me.'

'Borrowed,' Adora said automatically. 'It was an homage*,' she added, pronouncing the word with a flair of pretention, because that always made Catra laugh. She had to admit, the shoulder-piece* did *look like the matching part of She-Ra's outfit. She liked that. A little secret between the two of them.*

Catra snorted. 'Whatever you say, Adora.'

And just like that, she felt better again. Once upon a time, the uncertainty would have dogged her for days. That had been before. Now, Catra made everything easy.

'All right.' Adora grinned. 'Is the mighty bounty hunter Catra ready to subdue She-Ra in single combat?'

Catra clipped her whip to its place on her hip. Stretched, languorous, revealing the thinnest band of skin above the hem of her trousers. Her ears twitched forward.

'Believe me,' she purred. 'She's always *ready.'*

*

'What do you mean, *she brought She-Ra in?'*

Tero shifted on her feet and tried to summon the confidence she'd felt standing up to Catra. It was proving difficult, given how that had ended. 'Uh,' she said. 'She brought She-Ra in, Boss. I guess she saw the bounty posters? And she's a bounty hunter, that's what she… does. I guess.'

Boss was intimidating at the best of times, tall and grey-skinned and built like an upside down pyramid, all the power concentrated in her upper body; but when, as now, she had her eye patch off, revealing her scars, it was almost impossible to meet her eyes.

'Did you *see* She-Ra?'

'Not… exactly?' Tero cleared her throat. 'Isn't this good, Boss? That's why we put the posters up. Isn't it?'

'Tero. She-Ra brought down Lord Prime. She is one of the deadliest people in the galaxy. I did not put a bounty on her head because I expected anyone to *capture* her. I did it so the good citizens of Charobia would understand that she is *dangerous*. A criminal who destroyed the only source of *order* in the galaxy. And you *believed* the first two-bit bounty hunter who turned up at our door claiming to have her?'

Tero considered mentioning the things Catra had done with a power whip. On reflection, she decided against. Boss was a dangerous woman, and doubly so when she was in an *emphasising* mood.

‘I’d rate her at three bits at least, Boss,’ she said, and immediately regretted it. This wasn’t the time for levity. ‘Uh—I mean, she took out six of our people. I thought you’d want the opportunity to deal with her personally.’ There. That was a good bit of reasoning. It had nothing to do with the fact that Tero never wanted to be alone in a room with Catra again.

Boss flexed one hand. The sharp curves of her nails made their own point. ‘Very well then,’ she said, voice dripping sarcasm. ‘Let us go and deal with this *bounty hunter*.’

Tero judged it wiser not to speak during the walk back to the front room. She stopped in front of the door, steeling herself, but Boss had no such qualms, and it was either go in or hang back and reveal how disquieted the whole situation had made Tero feel. She went in.

The front room was deceptively calm: Omet and his friends had made themselves scarce. Catra was sitting in a chair in the middle of the room, legs crossed, a look of utter boredom on her face.

She wasn’t alone.

A woman knelt by her feet. She wore white from head to toe, and her blonde hair, matted with sweat, spilled around her shoulders. Her hands were bound behind her back. Her mouth was gagged. Catra’s hand sat lightly on her left shoulder. If it hadn’t been for the whip looped around the woman’s waist, it might almost have looked like the comforting touch of a lover.

‘That was seven minutes,’ Catra said, and Tero flinched. ‘But what’s a little tardiness between friends?’

Tero was still fighting the urge to apologise when Boss said, ‘That’s not She-Ra. Too short.’

‘Yeah, I thought you might say that.’ Catra unhooked something from her belt and tossed it onto the floor between them. ‘Good thing I had the camera running.’

The thing on the floor was nothing more hazardous than a video projector. Tero took half a step back anyway. The top of the little silver pyramid opened and the air above it shimmered into the crystal-clear lines of a Charobian hologram.

She-Ra stood with her back to them, bent over a control terminal on what looked like a ship, though the windows were blacked out. It was undeniably her. The details of what exactly had happened on Etheria were still sketchy, but all the accounts agreed in their descriptions of Lord Prime's nemesis: larger than life, white-and-gold, hair tied back in an impossibly long ponytail.

The image jerked forward. She-Ra spun around with a theatrical yelp of alarm, but Tero had no time to consider the implications of that fact because She-Ra had a sword in her hand, a huge, old-fashioned sword, and she was bringing it down on top of them, and Tero cowered away—

The viewpoint slid away like water. 'You'll have to do better than that,' came Catra's voice, and finally Tero realised the recording device must have been strapped to her chest, that they were seeing what she'd been seeing.

'I've beaten you before,' She-Ra proclaimed. Did she always speak like she was strutting around on a stage? Maybe that was what being eight foot tall did to you. 'I'll do it again!'

'Oh, princess, not this time.'

She-Ra yelled and swung again, all brute, shining strength; but Catra was too quick. The camera perspective shifted, fast, a blur of activity Tero couldn't follow, and a moment later She-Ra was on her back, Catra kicking the sword right out of her hands.

The camera shifted, pulling back. Catra must've had more than one recording device, because now Tero could see the both of them, She-Ra on her back glaring murderously at the woman on top of her, Catra pinning She-Ra's hands to the floor as she painstakingly wound the tail of her power whip around her arms.

A burst of light washed the image out for a moment. When it faded, She-Ra was gone; and in her place lay the woman who was even now staring daggers from her place at Catra's feet.

The Catra in the hologram dragged one claw along the woman's face. In reality, the same claw tapped a steady rhythm on her shoulder.

'You're mine,' Catra whispered, and Tero couldn't tell which had spoken, the hologram or the flesh and blood, but the words thrummed through her regardless, richer than a hunter merely apprehending her prey. There was shared history there, Tero would have bet on it.

The image vanished.

'That should clear things up,' Catra said briskly. 'One'—and was there the slightest hitch in her voice, the slightest hesitation before the next word?—'She-Ra, minus the stupid costume. Or would you like a hands-on demonstration?'

The woman on the floor—She-Ra—rolled her eyes at the words *stupid costume*. Tero frowned. She didn't *look* cowed, but then, if reports were to be believed, she'd brought down the most dangerous person in the galaxy. People like that probably didn't cower easily. Even when they were captives at someone's feet.

'There was no word of this… transformation in the reports I have from Etheria,' Boss said.

'Then your reports suck.' Catra narrowed her eyes. 'I was on Prime's flagship. I was there when he died. There's no better eyewitness than me.'

Boss' voice sharpened. 'You knew Lord Prime?'

Catra's ears folded back against her scalp. 'I did,' she said.

'And you have a way to prevent the transformation.'

‘I do.’ Catra’s tail brushed against the cuffs on She-Ra’s wrists. ‘I’ll throw them in for free.’

‘How do they work?’

‘Magic.’

‘Magic.’ Boss made the word deceptively soft. ‘An interesting choice you’ve made, bringing magic into my domain.’

Catra laughed, loud and sharp. ‘Deal with it. You didn’t even know about the transformation, and you expect me to believe you have a better solution? You have no idea what She-Ra is capable of. I do. I can take these off her if you really want, but I won’t be responsible for the consequences. Now,’ she added, ‘I am *aching* for a shower, so I’ll have my payment.’

‘It is a large sum.’ The words came slowly. It was the first time Tero had seen Boss admit to fallibility. The thought shook her. ‘I will need a few days to—’

Catra cut her off with a dismissive wave of her hand. ‘Forget that. I don’t want money.’

‘What *do* you want?’

Catra stood. Her hands formed fists. She crossed the gap between them and stared Boss in the face.

‘I was raised by the Horde,’ she said in a low, urgent whisper. ‘I watched She-Ra destroy it. Then I watched her take to the stars and spread the *plague* of magic to every planet she touched—’

‘Boss,’ Tero said suddenly. Something was wrong. She couldn’t say why, but something was *wrong*. ‘Boss, I don’t think we should—’

‘*Tero,’* Boss snapped. ‘My apologies,’ she added to Catra. ‘I ask again: what do you want?’

Catra's smile became all-encompassing. 'I want revenge,' she said. 'I want *in*.'

*

Bow and Glimmer saw them off: Catra in her bounty hunter finery, Adora with a pair of chainless padded cuffs already circling her wrists in a fetching shade of dark red. The Inheritors' compound was a fair way out from the city—the plan was to pay a local to take them out—but it wouldn't hurt to maintain the charade right from the start.

Glimmer pulled a copy of the bounty poster out of her pocket. 'Wait, do you have one of these? Aren't bounty hunters supposed to bring the wanted notice with them?'

'Wait, why do you have one?' Bow said.

'Uh, because I kept one? Obviously?'

'I put one up on our wall,' Adora added.

'Are you kidding?' Catra grinned. 'I took twenty. I'm going to send them to all our friends.'

Bow raised his eyes ceilingwards. 'Why do I bother asking these things.'

Glimmer kissed his cheek. 'Because someone needs to keep the rest of us in check.' She hesitated a moment, then stepped forward and pulled first Adora, then Catra into a firm embrace. 'Bow and I will be far *too busy with diplomacy to come rescue you. So be careful, okay?'*

'When are we not?' Adora said, smiling.

'Always,' Bow said immediately.

'Literally all the time,' Catra agreed. She tossed the recording pyramid from one hand to another. 'But it's okay. Between my

incredible skill at bullshitting and Adora's, I don't know, magic sparkly hero luck or whatever, we'll be fine.'

Glimmer looked on the verge of objecting to sparkly hero luck. *Instead, she took a step back. 'All right. We'll leave you to it.'*

And with one last smile, Catra and Adora were alone at the top of Darla's ramp. A few more steps, and their ruse would begin for real. Adora took a deep breath. She was subtle about it, but Catra's hearing was sharp and always attuned to her lover. She stepped closer, into Adora's orbit.

'Hey,' Catra murmured. 'One last moment of us?'

Adora smiled. Her hand found Catra's check, drew her in like there was a thread between them. Her lips were soft. Catra breathed the kiss in, let it settle in her soul. The moment stretched and pulled the thread taut.

'All right.' Adora stepped back, smile still in place. 'Let's go.'

*

The door of her cell slammed shut, leaving Adora in almost total darkness. The bars were shiny and spotless but old-fashioned, the kind of prison bars captors talked to their captives through. The walls were made of the same stuff as the rest of the building, except here they were shot through with a murky blackness, like ink dispersing in water. Adora pressed a hand against it experimentally. The wall was soft and yielding, conforming easily to the shape of her hand, but if she tried to push more than a few inches in it resisted her like steel. Still—her sword could probably cut through it, and even if it couldn't, the bars wouldn't stand a chance. She sat down, adjusted the altogether unmagical cuffs where they had begun to chafe a little, and rubbed her hands together.

The plan was going off without a hitch.

'I don't trust you.'

Adora's head snapped up. She'd thought she was alone. Catra and the woman who was obviously in charge had delivered her to the cell and left, the spiky echo of Catra's laughter pricking her skin, and—oh. It was the other one. The underling.

'I never would have guessed,' Adora said, aiming for the same sort of *I could break your neck if I really wanted to* confidence that Catra could still, apparently, switch on at will. She wasn't sure it was working. Catra exuded it; with Adora it was more like a wet cough. 'What with the cell and all.'

The underling—Tero, her leader had called her—stepped into the faint light. She was tall and heavily muscled and she probably thought the way the shadows played across her skin made her look intimidating, but Adora had been intimidated by *far* better people. Least of all Catra.

'You're not scared,' Tero said.

That brought Adora up short. 'Uh.' She didn't have a script for this. 'I guess… not?'

'Why not?'

'Because, uh, I'm She-Ra! The… Magnificent!' There, that was better. It was too late to play the beaten-down prisoner, so this would have to do. 'I faced Lord Prime in single combat and emerged victorious! None can stand against me.'

'Except Catra.'

'Right,' Adora said, and then, in her newly acquired She-Ra-the-Magnificent voice, 'How *dare* you speak that name in my presence!'

'You,' Tero said, and she sounded almost impressed, 'are a *terrible* actor.'

'I'm not—what? I'm not acting. This is how I am. All the time.'

‘Listen to me.’ Tero wrapped a hand around one of the prison bars. Her nails were worn and chipped. ‘I don’t know what your plan is, or what the fuck that was with Catra back there—’

‘Don’t say that name, I *hate* Catra—’

‘—but I’m not going to let some petty fucking feud from a *backwater* like Etheria get in the way of what we’re doing here. So let’s make this easy, all right, and you can just forget getting revenge on Catra or *whatever* it is you want, and sit back until Boss has a use for you. How does that sound?’

Adora couldn’t help herself. She tried not to sound too interested, but—‘What *are* you doing here?’

Tero frowned. Moved back a little. Her voice lost some of its edge. ‘I said, *How does that sound?*’

‘Oh, uh, sounds great, but—wait, you didn’t answer my question!’

Tero ignored her and disappeared around the corner. The same corner that had swallowed Catra. Adora waited a few minutes, just in case, but now she really was alone.

Okay. Take stock. So maybe Tero suspected she was up to something. At least she didn’t know Adora and Catra were working together. That was good. And the cuffs were only bothering here a little bit. They weren’t even uncomfortable exactly, just… present.

Just in case, she thought, and held out one arm. A whisper: ‘For the honour of Grayskull.’

Nothing happened.

Cold sweat ran down Adora’s back. ‘For the honour of Grayskull,’ she repeated, a little louder, visions of Catra and Bow and Glimmer running through her mind, the four of them lounging on Darla’s bridge, laughing—

A faint glow suffused the room, grew stronger, coalesced into the familiar shape of her sword in the gloom. Adora breathed a sigh of relief, then startled when a tremor ran through the building. Quickly she extinguished the sword. If there was an earthquake, someone might come and check on her; but the tremor died down within seconds, and the corridor outside remained silent.

Adora put Charobian tectonic activity out of her mind. Everything was fine. Catra was in, learning what she could, and Adora had She-Ra at the ready.

The plan was going off *mostly* without a hitch.

*

The cell hadn't made a noise when Catra closed it on Adora. She'd expected the clang of metal hitting metal, or the screech of an unoiled hinge. But the bars were spotless, rustless; and whatever mechanism held the door shut didn't rely on metal. It put her in mind of the cells in the Fright Zone, with only a silent force field separating captive from captor. Catra made a conscious effort to keep her ears from folding back. She'd beaten Hordak, and she'd beaten everything the Crimson Waste threw at her, and she'd even beaten Horde Prime, in the end. In a manner of speaking. It didn't matter what kind of cell these people used to hold Adora—Adora could break herself out, and even if she couldn't, it wouldn't matter.

Catra would win here, too.

'Catra. Walk with me.'

Catra was good at snap judgements. The woman who called herself Boss was no Horde Prime, or even a Hordak. She was a Tung Lashor at best: tall, powerful, muscles coiled with the promise of brutal force, but ultimately no more than a second string leader with a gang of lackeys who didn't know better. That much was obvious from the faint hum of conversation coming from the cell area. Even through the black-tinted walls

surrounding the prison, Catra could recognise the cadence of someone trying too hard to sound tough.

And the sound of someone doing a terrible job acting. Internally, Catra winced. One day she'd have to teach Adora how to do a convincing impression of, well, anyone.

'*Catra*.'

Boss was doing a convincing impression. She wore a diagonal slash of black across the left side of her face, like an eyepatch that covered everything *but* her eye. It made her expression oddly difficult to read. The effect, Catra had to admit, was a little unnerving.

'I heard you the first time,' Catra said in her cocky-bounty-hunter drawl.

'Walk with me.'

Catra put a saunter in her step as she complied. It was almost *fun*, playing the role of the arrogant bounty hunter, and she focused on that feeling. Why *not* let herself have fun? It was better than the alternative—better than dwelling on the real part of her life she was emulating.

Boss led her through the corridors of her headquarters. It was a large building, gossamer-light away from the gloom of the prison cells, swaying slightly below Catra's feet. Where had it come from? Why was it so far from the rest of the city? If Bow was right, and the floating buildings represented the upper class of Charobian cities, did that confirm that Boss was in league with the planetary government?

'Here,' Boss said, stopping in front of an open door. There was an empty room beyond, set up for a single occupant. Catra's ears perked up at the sight of a bathroom at the far end. She hadn't been kidding about the shower. 'This will be your room for the duration of your stay.'

Catra made a show of looking around the room. ‘It’ll do.’ She paused just long enough to make Boss think she had the upper hand, then turned and met her gaze. ‘For now.’

Boss bristled. ‘Let me be clear with you, *Catra*—’

‘Oh, by the way,’ Catra interrupted, cursing herself even as she said the words. Better to let Boss rant if she was so inclined—it made her look weak, and in an organisation like this, looking weak was the same as being weak. But there’d been something too familiar about the way she emphasised Catra's name, something that made Catra cut her off by reflex. ‘Do you always show new recruits around? Or only when you know they might replace you?’

‘I don’t know who you think you are,’ Boss said, quiet, dangerous. ‘I am *allowing* you to stay because you have information that may be of—’

‘You’re allowing me to stay because I did what you thought no one could do. I captured She-Ra. And now you're scared of me, so you think keeping me close makes you safer.’ Catra grinned wide. ‘It really doesn’t.’

‘You will come with me,’ Boss said flatly. ‘And you will tell me *everything* I want to know.’

‘Nah. I need a nap—’

‘Boss!’

There was a man hurrying down the corridor, tall like everyone here was tall and vaguely reminiscent of the lackey Catra had steamrolled in the entrance chamber. Catra could feel Boss' attention shifting to him, as if trying to work out how much of Catra’s disdain he’d overheard.

‘What is it, Neto?’

‘There’s a message for you. From the—’ Neto glanced at Catra. ‘City,’ he finished.

Oh well. Too much to hope he'd let slip exactly who was sending Boss messages. It was valuable enough knowing there *were* messages.

Boss' fingers curled. 'With me,' she said, jerking her head at Neto. Her eyes found Catra. 'You—I'm not done with you.'

'Wouldn't dream of it.' Part of Catra was desperately curious what the two of them had to talk about; but she'd dug herself a shower-shaped hole. It would be suspicious if she showed too much interest now. 'But take your time. My calendar's pretty full. How's Friday?'

Boss stared at her. Catra grinned back. Then they were gone, and Catra was alone in the corridor.

Not a bad start, she thought, half an hour later with her leather off and the shower soothing the places where it chafed. Not a bad start at all.

*

The dark wasn't getting to Adora.

That would be silly—she wasn't afraid of the dark. And besides, every so often the lights got a little brighter and someone came in and brought her food. That was nice of them. Given she could break out of the cell whenever she wanted, it really wasn't that much different to being stuck on Darla. Not different at all.

She rubbed her cuffs and wondered how Catra was getting on.

Some time later—she was losing track, honestly; maybe a day or two—she got her answer. The lights came on. Adora strained to make out faces: there was Tero, and behind her the woman who Tero called *Boss* as if it was her name, and behind *her*—Adora sighed in relief. Catra looked fine. Better than fine—she walked like she owned the place, or at any rate could take it for herself whenever she wanted.

See, Adora thought, nothing to worry about. You can break out whenever you want, and Catra can take over half a dozen underground criminal organisations before breakfast. Everything's fine.

'Hey, Adora,' Catra drawled, in a way Adora found intimately familiar but hadn't heard in a long time. Mocking. Flirtatious. Her pulse quickened. There was something—*distracting* about hearing Catra talk like that again. And not in a bad way. Adora's gaze flicked from Catra's sharp little smile to the whip clipped to her belt and back. She tried not to blush. Was pretty sure she'd failed when Catra's smile widened and she added, 'What's it like being in my cell? *Again?*'

'Again?' Boss said sharply.

'Oh, we go *way* back, Adora and I. Why do you think I'm so good at taking her down?'

'Not good at keeping her, apparently.'

'Ha! I like you,' and again Adora marvelled at the way Catra could talk down to a woman who was both literally and figuratively higher up than her. That was new. The old Catra, the one who'd risen to command the Horde, had always had an edge of insecurity about her, even when she was in charge. Adora felt a burst of pride, then remembered she probably shouldn't be encouraging her girlfriend's skills in the *evil villain* category.

'Let me tell you a secret,' Catra was saying. 'Once you have her, She-Ra's *easy*. The trouble is, she always has a half dozen little friends clamouring to the rescue.' She squatted in front of the cell and dragged a single claw down one of the prison bars. It sounded like the cuffs around Adora's wrists felt. 'So,' Catra said softly, 'all I had to do was take her somewhere she had none. No friends, no rescue… no hope.'

For all Adora *knew* Catra was acting, she couldn't help looking for some sign in her eyes, some signal just for her. 'You'll never get

what you want,' she said, weakly, and for once she thought *her* acting was pretty good, too.

'Hmm.' Boss was looking at Adora like she was a particularly mediocre pile of fruit at a market stall. 'What about the people who arrived with her? They were seen together in the city.'

Catra paused. 'You don't have to worry. I took care of them when I captured She-Ra.'

'Are you sure?'

'Perfectly.'

'Nevertheless. Now that I know she has a history of… prison breaks, I don't like her hands being free. Bind them.'

'She's already got the cuffs—'

'Bind them.'

Adora tried not to panic. This wasn't in the plan. Boss had gotten the better of Catra, and that wasn't the plan at *all*. Surely Catra would come up with something—but no, there she was, hesitating a moment too long before nodding acquiescence. Boss unlocked the cell. Catra stepped through.

Sharing a space with Catra again should have been comforting. It was just like Darla, she thought. Normal. No reason to scramble away until her back was up against the wall, no reason at all—

Catra reached out for her hands. Adora jerked away, instinctively. Catra's ears folded back.

'Feisty,' Catra said, loud, for the benefit of the others. 'You'd think you'd be used to do this by now.' Then she caught Adora's wrists in one hand, unclipped another pair of cuffs from her belt—the normal kind, with a chain between them—and slipped them on, one after the other. She leaned in when she did it. Adora could feel her breath on her shoulders. One of her claws scraped the

side of Adora's wrist. Adora couldn't tell if it was deliberate or not. It made her shiver either way.

At least Catra's touch was gentle.

It made no difference, Adora told herself. The new cuffs would just fall off the moment she transformed into She-Ra. Sure, eating would be less convenient, but she could manage that. It didn't change anything *important*. She gritted her teeth, held her breath, tried not to think about the fresh weights around her wrists; and if Catra had words for Adora's ears alone, as quiet and ephemeral as the house-pods of Charobia on the wind; if Catra brushed her tail against those same wrists as she stood, if the touch dragged on too long to be accidental; if these things all happened, was it Adora's fault that she did not notice?

'There,' Catra said, back on the other side of the prison bars. She sounded bored, and then sarcastically annoyed when she added, 'Or do you think we should bind her legs as well?'

'No, this will do quite nicely.' Boss leaned back against one wall and crossed her arms, as if settling in for the long haul. 'Now, She-Ra, you will tell me everything you know about the demise of Lord Prime.' Her lips peeled back. 'And everything about how his mistakes may be avoided in the future.'

This, Adora was ready for. These lies Adora had prepared. This role Adora could play. She made herself small and submitted to the interrogation of her captor.

Later, alone, the memory of Catra's touch burning on her wrist, Adora whispered the words to herself, *For the honour of Grayskull*, again and again and again, and each time they failed she thought, that one didn't count; I wasn't really trying; this next one's for real, just to make sure; until her lips were dry and her cell resolutely unlit by the golden light of She-Ra, and she lay down and curled her body around the memory of Catra's warmth and told herself it would have worked, the next time, She-Ra would

have come, but her wrist was starting to ache from holding up the cuffs and what was the point in proving a foregone conclusion?

*

A few days later, Catra stepped out of her room and found herself face to face with Neto.

'Boss wants you,' he said.

Catra gestured for him to lead the way. Other than the time Boss had taken her to see Adora—and Catra still winced to remember the hard metal cuffs around Adora's wrists—she'd been left to her own devices. She'd fallen back on old instincts and spent the time exploring. She had a decent mental map of the complex by now, but it wouldn't do to let on to that fact. As far as anyone else was concerned, she was the moody, violent stranger who'd caught their leader's attention. That was all.

'Funny thing,' Catra said. Neto grunted something that might have been a reply. 'It actually *is* Friday,' she went on. 'Coincidence, do you think? Or is she always so…' Catra paused long enough that the next words were unmistakably an insult. 'Literal minded?'

Neto didn't respond, but he did stop. For a moment, Catra thought he was going to make something of her disrespect; but no, there was a door here, a large one she hadn't been through before. He palmed it open, gestured her through, and closed it between them.

Leaving her alone in what was clearly Boss' office. The wall at the far end was transparent, offering a gorgeous view of the Charobian landscape and, in the distance, the lines of the city: a confection of gossamer structures rooted to the ground by the stalks of giant mushrooms. Not for the first time, Catra wondered how Boss had gotten *this* particular building so far out. It was one of the floating ones; maybe it was as simple as severing all the connections to adjacent structures and towing it.

The mental image made her laugh.

‘What is it that makes someone like you laugh, I wonder?’

Catra froze. There was no one in the room, she was sure of it.

‘The thought of She-Ra in chains, perhaps? Tero thinks you know her better than you’re letting on, you know.’

Still nothing. Catra’s ears folded back. Her tail lashed in agitation.

‘Theatrics?’ she said into the empty air. ‘Prime was a fan of theatrics. You heard what happened to him.’

Boss laughed. She winked into existence on the other side of a massive desk, her head framed by the nauseatingly organic shapes of an equally organic chair—the kind of chair Boss probably thought of as a throne. ‘Personal cloaking technology,’ she said. ‘The Charobians truly are marvellous, aren’t they? Of course, they don’t have the imagination to use it. Not like me.’

‘What’s that supposed to mean?’

Boss studied her for several long seconds. Then she said, ‘How many eyes does Prime have?’

‘*What?*’

‘You heard me.’

‘Four,’ Catra snapped, ‘and you mean *did*. How many *did* he have.’

‘What was the name of his flagship?’

‘The Velvet Glove. What the fuck is this, twenty questions?’

‘And how did he die?’

Catra’s nails bit into her palms. ‘I don’t know. Some kind of She-Ra magic bullshit.’ That was true enough. Even Adora wasn’t entirely sure how she’d banished Prime. ‘Ad—She-Ra already gave you all this information.’

Boss twisted her lips around her teeth in what might, somewhere in the universe that wasn't here, have been a smile. '*Ad-She-Ra*,' she said. 'Fascinating.'

Catra bared her own teeth. Her fingers itched with the need to unsheathe her claws. It would be so easy. So easy to wipe that expression off the other woman's face, to topple her, to assert herself at the top of the pile like she'd done with Shadow Weaver, with Tung Lashor, with Hardok—

And not with Prime.

Catra forced herself to relax. She wasn't here to *take over*. She was here to learn things. She'd slipped up twice now; once in the cell, with the cuffs, and again now. Maybe she was out of practice. Maybe she'd underestimated Boss. Either way: Catra was good at turning mistakes into opportunities.

'What do you want from me?' she muttered, hunching her shoulders in what she hoped was a cowed manner.

Boss' not-a-smile grew wider. 'There, was that so hard? You claim that we are not enemies, Catra. I am not unwilling to work with you towards a common goal.'

'What goal?' Catra kept her voice neutral, even as her heart beat faster with curiosity.

'Horde Prime took everything from me.' Boss said this like it was the most casual of observations. 'And now I will take everything that was his.'

'Horde Prime is *gone*. His empire is gone.'

'His armies, yes. And his clones. But the worlds he conquered, they're still there. The structures of his rule are still there. All I need to do is slip into them, and the galaxy will fall back in line. And without Prime, the Charobians are the most technologically advanced civilisation in the universe. Do you see, Catra?'

‘It won’t work. She-Ra’s been helping those planets. By the time you show up—’

‘Nothing will have changed, because She-Ra is *mine* now.’

It took all of Catra’s self-control not to snarl *No, she’s* mine.

‘But you’re right. She’s a threat. All of Etheria is a threat.’ Boss spread her arms magnanimously. ‘But with *you* on our side—you know how She-Ra beat Prime. You can help us avoid the same fate. And once we’re done, you can do whatever you want with Etheria. I don’t need it. I’ll have the rest of the universe.’

Catra almost rolled her eyes. It was all so—*typical*. Of course she could have Etheria. ‘I don’t want—’ she began, and then she looked up, and the blood froze solid in her veins. ‘No,’ she whispered. ‘No, you’re—'

Boss had taken off the binding that obscured her left eye. Above and beneath it, scarred but unmistakeable, were the empty sockets of two smaller eyes. Eyes that blazed green in Catra’s memory, that filled her lungs with the cloying taste of helplessness. Stupid, stupid, stupid, she should have *noticed*—the shape of Boss’ skull was a little different, smaller, flatter, but the *eyes*—

‘You *did* know Prime,’ Boss breathed, so quiet Catra could barely hear.

Boss’ eyes—the whole ones—were red. Catra swallowed. She tried to make her voice hard, calloused, but it was impossible to hide the memories swarming her, making her fur stand up on the back of her neck. ‘Like I said.’ She drew in a ragged breath. ‘Who—who *are* you?’

‘A thousand years ago,’ Boss said, still in that quiet, solemn voice, ‘a man who did not yet call himself Horde Prime came to a planet, and he stole everything. The planet’s name. Its technology. The bodies of its *people*. Everything—except me.’

*

That night Catra had the nightmare.

This time it started in the loft she and Adora had bought in Erelandia. It was early morning. The sun was just creeping above the window boxes by their bed and the smells of the bakery downstairs were permeating the air. Adora was already awake, sitting up in bed and looking out the window. Her face was angled away from Catra, and the geometry of the dream kept it that way. No matter what Catra did, she never saw more than the barest edge of Adora's smile.

The smell of bread turned green. So did the sunlight streaming into the window. Catra wrapped her arms around herself, made herself as small as possible, but it was no use. She couldn't avoid the colour forever, and when the light finally touched her, when the scent of it filled her nostrils and made her ears flatten in terror, she woke up.

Catra's fur was heavy with liquid that wasn't water. It surrounded her. Filled her lungs. Even when she broke the surface, it stuck to her like a dusting of pollen. She opened her eyes. Horde Prime sat next to the purification pool with the patient smile she'd learned to loathe more than anything else, the smile of someone who expected to live many millennia beyond his first.

'Again, Catra?' he said. 'Haven't you learnt yet that there can be no joy for you? It will be easier if you submit. Tell me what you know of She-Ra, and we can put this unpleasantness behind us.'

Tell me what you know of She-Ra, the mirror to Boss asking Adora, *Tell me everything you know about the demise of Lord Prime*, and that was what broke the dream this time.

'You are *gone*,' Catra snarled, and before her unsheathed claws had the satisfaction of taking Prime's face apart, she woke up again. Charobia, this time. Awake for real. She could tell by the gelatinous texture of the wall beneath her claws.

In reality, Prime hadn’t cared enough to oversee her brainwashing. That part of the nightmare didn’t bother Catra anymore. She knew he was gone. She knew it deep enough that the knowledge bubbled to the surface even in sleep. The other part was worse: the caricature of happiness, Adora stiff and unyielding like a puppet. The way one particular shade of green still made Catra stiffen even in the most innocuous of contexts.

The nightmare didn’t come as often as it once did. Every time she woke from it to find Adora already awake, holding her, stroking hair matted with sweat and nothing else, it lost a little more of its power. Every time the nightmare was false, reality became truer.

She’d made peace with the fact that it might never leave her entirely. That was fine. She knew how to cope with it. Even now, alone, further from Adora than she’d been in months, she knew what to do. She’d prepared for this.

Catra reached under her pillow. The pyramid of metal she’d hidden there dug into her palm. She didn’t bring it out, didn’t activate it. She didn’t need to.

It was enough to know what was inside.

Chapter End Notes

with apologies to the people who liked the bow and glimmer dynamic in chapter one. I realised pretty quick that I'd bitten off more than I could chew and my options were to half-ass the whole fic or to, uh, whole-ass half the fic, and the latter was clearly the better option lol.

anyway, let me know what you thought, and look forward to the final chapter on saturday! :)

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

happy catradora day, everyone!

this chapter comes with more gorgeous art by kladderier: check it out here!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Tero told herself she'd only been seeing things.

Catra had done what Boss wanted. She'd put the extra cuffs on She-Ra. Why did it matter *how* she did it? Why did it matter that her touch had seemed bizarrely soft, that her lips had moved imperceptibly? That her tail had lingered around She-Ra's hands like a character in a romance, reluctant to cease contact with a lover? Catra wasn't hiding her history with She-Ra. It was probably a taunt, nothing more, some petty victory meant for She-Ra's ears alone.

And yet.

The thought wouldn't leave Tero alone, not when she stood guard outside Boss' headquarters, not when she made the trip into the city to spread Boss' propaganda among the unwitting citizenry of Charobia.

Lord Prime's empire would rise again, from the pristine ashes of Charobia, its technology unmarred by the stain of magic. Lord Prime's empire would rise again, except it wouldn't be Lord Prime's at all. It would be Boss', and Tero would be at her shoulder when it happened.

That was what she ought to be focusing on.

Instead, she found herself hovering outside the room Boss had assigned to Catra. A private room—not the dormitory the rest of

them shared. Not that Tero was jealous. Catra was a shiny new bauble for Boss to play with, that was all. A shiny new bauble with a smile that could cut a person down to half her size and eyes that Tero was half convinced were lying in ambush around every corner, but still. And it wasn't like Catra was there. Tero could see that easily enough. Even after several months on the planet, she hadn't quite gotten used to Charobia and its translucent walls. What did they do for privacy? Put up a screen?

Tero bit her lower lip, hard. This wasn't helping. Catra was away, ingratiating her way into Boss' trust with more stories of Lord Prime, no doubt, and that meant Tero had an opportunity. Before her nerve failed her, she reached out and brushed the door control. It shivered open like a squishy marine creature shying away from her touch.

The room was almost empty. A bed, a table, a chair. In the back, an equally empty bathroom. Apart from a few changes of clothes, there was nothing to mark it as belonging to the bounty hunter who'd supposedly captured She-Ra.

Tero sat down on the bed—it was unmade, Catra would never notice—and sighed. What had she expected? A datachip on the table marked *TERO DO NOT READ PROOF OF TREACHERY INSIDE?* She'd wasted all that time talking herself into searching Catra's room, when she could have done it in five minutes and been on her way. She leaned back and stared at the ceiling.

And frowned.

There was something hard under Catra's pillow. Tero could feel it digging into her elbow.

She pulled it out. It was the recording device Catra had used to prove She-Ra was She-Ra. The one with the footage of their fight. Footage Tero had already seen, but…

Why would Catra keep it under her *pillow?*

Tero placed it flat on the desk and thumbed it on. The hologram filled almost the entire room: the same image Catra had paused the recording on, her claws on She-Ra's cheek, her whip around her arms. If bounty hunters had instruction manuals, this would be the picture under *Successfully Subduing Your Prey.* And yet: Catra hadn't let the recording run its course. She'd paused it. Why?

Tero hit play.

*

Adora ate her breakfast with wooden hands.

The new cuffs were even more troublesome than she'd expected. She'd been given some sort of flatbread that day, lightly spiced and chewy—food she would have enjoyed, in other circumstances—but tearing it into strips small enough to eat was proving problematic. Her shoulders hunched forward, matching the cramp in her wrists. The cell itself felt smaller.

She hadn't tried for She-Ra again.

None of this was what Adora had expected. The hard part, she'd assumed, would be seeing Catra act the part of villain again. She'd prepared for that. Gone through reassurances in her head: *You love Catra. She loves you. None of that changes. Trust her.* But Adora knew that was all true, and yet she still found herself here, drawn up small in a cell that shouldn't have been able to hold her.

She loved Catra. Even when Catra was all swagger and mockery, even when she looked at Adora like she really was thrilled to see her behind bars—even then, there was something electric between them. The same thing that had always been there. Catra now blurred with Catra then. And that was the problem.

They'd left that in the past. Turned a new leaf. Written a new page. It was bad to be reminded of the past and think that nothing had changed. Wasn't it?

Adora closed her eyes. Her thoughts swirled. She'd been sleeping badly.

Some time later, the door to the cell block slid open—nearly soundless, like all Charobian doors, but in her silence and her solitude, Adora's hearing was nearly as acute as Catra's. She summoned the will to open her eyes and look up.

'Hello, *She-Ra*.'

Tero had a glint in her eye and a curve to her lips that Adora found weirdly jarring. It was like the other woman was acting the part of captor as much as Adora was acting the captive, as if one bad actor could recognise another.

'What do you want?' she said, too tired for the words to come out as anything but sincere.

Tero's grin showed teeth. 'I found something interesting under Catra's pillow,' she said. 'I want you to explain this.' She unlocked the cell with all the bravado of someone who outweighed her prisoner two to one and placed a small metal pyramid on the floor between them.

Stupid, Adora thought, to come into the cell—but then Tero thumbed the pyramid on, and the image filled her cell almost completely. The corridor outside would have been too narrow. It was the same projector Catra had used the day they'd arrived, on which Bow had recorded She-Ra's "capture". Adora frowned. Where had Tero gotten it?

The hologram played from the beginning, but Tero paused it when it got to Catra, leaning over Adora with her arms bound, her claw dimpling one of Adora's cheeks, smiling that jagged smile and—

Adora's lip twitched with amusement. That was what was bothering her about Tero: her smile was Catra's smile, her drawl Catra's drawl—but muted, without the fangs, without the rasp, without the confidence that made them work when it was Catra. When it was Catra, dangerous and seductive and *gorgeous*, like

she'd been for three long years; when it was her claws on Adora's skin in earnest, her voice mocking in Adora's ear, when the sight of her made Adora's heartbeat spike with adrenaline.

Lately the sight of Catra had induced a different reaction. Soft, ambient. Less like a beacon and more like the light of dawn, filling a room so it was almost impossible to tell the source. It was a good thing, Adora had thought, a gentle thing; but now, the hologram of Catra the bounty hunter hovering above her, a different word occurred to her.

Muted.

Any mockery she might have directed at Tero for her half-hearted imitation of Catra died in Adora's throat. How had Tero known to show her this? She couldn't possibly tell what Adora was thinking, what insecurities were refusing to boil away in the silence of her cell—

'Why here?' Tero asked, and by the cadence of her voice, Adora thought she'd been speaking for some time. 'Why would Catra not show us what happened next, I wondered? So I took the liberty of finding out.'

Adora's mind flashed back to that moment on the bridge, Bow behind the camera, Glimmer rolling her eyes, *Don't forget to delete that, Catra—*

And then she didn't need her memories, because the scene was playing out in the air in front of her. Catra's expression softened. Her fingers still lingered on Adora's cheek, but her claws were retracted when she leaned in and kissed Adora. It was the kind of kiss that toed the line of propriety not for its passion but its intimacy, that sparked in Adora a hundred memories of mornings shared. She blushed to see it projected so openly, as if her feelings were projected with it, the languid joy of exploring a moment with no goal but enjoying Catra's company; and she thought, *Catra kept this, even though it was dangerous*; and, *she kept it under her pillow, where it would be safe*; and then the

recording paused just as Catra pulled away, leaving Tero behind, staring at Adora with sharp triumph.

Adora was confused. Why the triumph? The kiss had settled something inside her. Put right the emotions a week of captivity had upended. She wouldn't feel entirely better until she had Catra in their room on Darla, until the recording became reality again; but the insecurity she'd been wallowing in was gone.

Then Tero said, 'You thought you could get one over on us?' and Adora remembered that, actually, they had a goal here, and for all the good watching the recording had done for her emotions, it had also blown a gigantic hole right through the heart of the plan; and then Tero added, 'Catra's with Boss right now. What do you think will happen to her when I tell Boss you'd rather be kissing her than fighting her?' and the rest of Adora's uncertainty disappeared before her rage.

'For the honour of Grayskull!'

Transforming into She-Ra had been a different experience, once. Before she'd broken the sword. Brilliant, blinding, but cold—like a spotlessly clean conference room kept a few degrees below comfortable. Now it was different. Warm. Filling, not draining. She let that warmth flow through her, visualised the sword appearing in the steady glow by her right hand.

The overhead lights flickered. She-Ra's glow went out. Adora stared at her hand.

'Wait,' said Tero, who'd retreated back behind the cell door and now shuffled forwards again. 'Catra wasn't lying? The cuffs *work*? Ha! I can't believe you'd be so stupid to *actually* disarm yourself!'

That couldn't be right. They'd agreed, they'd said the cuffs were fake, there was no way Catra could *actually* block She-Ra, anyway, it had to be something else—

Adora took a breath. Her gaze settled on the hologram, still projected where Tero had left it: Catra's lips half an inch from

hers, frozen in a mischievous smile. It didn't matter that she was wearing her bounty hunter's outfit. It didn't matter that her whip was still wound around Adora's wrists. The smile was real. The Catra she loved was real, somewhere beyond the cell. Waiting.

Potentially in danger.

Adora didn't bother trying for She-Ra again. She lunged forward and brought her joined hands down on Tero's head, the hard edges of the handcuffs giving the blow more power than it should have had. Tero tried to duck out of the way, but surprise threw her off-balance, and Adora was pretty sure she didn't have much experience of *actual* combat. She stumbled, hit her back on the prison bars, whirled away from them reflexively—and Adora took advantage of the opening to slip through the open cell door and slam it shut behind her.

The tussle had taken all of ten seconds. Tero, safely locked in Adora's erstwhile cell, found her footing and looked up, rubbing at the back of her head with one hand. 'What—'

'You're right, actually,' Adora said, and she couldn't quite hide the glee in her voice. She'd blame it on the adrenaline. 'Catra is lying through her *teeth*, and she's incredibly good at it. If she didn't have a soft spot a mile wide you'd never have caught on.' She flashed Tero a cocky grin. 'Good decision, confronting me instead of her. All I'm going to do is leave you here until your boss finally notices.'

'But you're—' Tero sounded lost. Adora almost felt sorry for her. 'You were bound! And you couldn't transform, you, you weren't supposed to be able to escape! I did everything *right*.'

'No,' Adora said. '*She-Ra* was bound. I'm Adora, and for better or worse I spent the first eighteen years of my life learning how to fight *without* a magic sword.'

Tero's slack-jawed expression nearly made Adora laugh. Stars, but it felt good to show the world—or, at least, this one, misguided

henchperson in a far-flung corner of the world—she knew who she was. That she was *confident* in who she was. Usually she left that kind of thing to Catra, but—well, Adora saw the appeal. Sometimes there was no substitute for reiterating her own self-worth. She deserved it: she'd earned it.

The days of confinement washed off in waves of bravado, leaving her lighter, cleaner. There was still the problem of the cuffs, and of what exactly was going wrong with She-Ra—but that could wait.

Right now, Catra was in trouble.

*

When Catra turned a corner and found Adora standing in the middle of the corridor, hands still cuffed but otherwise looking like herself, she didn't hesitate.

Never mind that Boss was right behind her; never mind that the other woman clearly thought she'd cowed Catra for good, that Catra had been planning to take advantage of that fact and extract as much information as possible.

It had been a good plan, but Catra was sick and tired of pretending Adora belonged in a cell.

Catra unsheathed her claws, turned, and leapt straight at Boss. The other woman went down, her bulk no match for the element of surprise. Catra pushed off her stomach before she could orient herself, heard the *huff* of escaping breath, and then she was running back down the corridor the way they'd come. She didn't bother checking that Adora was following. She could hear her footsteps, in sync with Catra's even though her arms were restrained; and above them the harsh bark of Boss calling for reinforcements. Safe place now; reunion later.

The door to Boss' office was locked, but Catra had swiped an access card on her second day. She ushered Adora inside and told the door not to open for anyone. Then she turned, and Adora was in her arms almost before she'd opened them. Adora's hands

wedged awkwardly between them, but that didn't matter, and neither did the distant sounds of pursuit reverberating through the floor.

'Hey, Adora,' Catra murmured into the crook of her neck, and at the sound of her name, Adora relaxed. Every other couple Catra knew had gone all in on pet names from day one, but she'd never felt the need. Adora's name was enough. It had always been enough.

'Hey yourself,' Adora mumbled. She wasn't crying, but there was something of tears in her voice, something gently cathartic.

'You okay?'

'Yeah.'

There was more to that thought, Catra could tell. She waited for Adora to finish.

'Maybe we should have, uh, thought this plan through. A bit more.'

Catra laughed. The hairs on Adora's neck stood up where her breath touched them. 'Come on. This way.'

'Where are we going?'

'I'm pretty sure there's a secret passage here,' Catra said, gesturing to the blank wall to the left of Boss' desk. 'Boss seems like the type. Plus I've been all over this building and there's definitely something here you can't get to from anywhere else.' She slashed at the wall experimentally. Her claws went straight through, and the wall peeled away like a zipper opening, revealing a corridor. 'See?'

'I'm impressed,' Adora said. 'I mean, I know every inch of the cell I was in by heart, but that was much smaller.'

‘Exploring large structures with lots of corridors is my speciality.’ Catra finished the hole with a flourish and stepped aside. ‘After you.’

Catra was pleasantly surprised by how easily the wall sealed behind them. The gelatinous material stuck to itself like it wanted to be whole again. The seam would be visible if anyone looked closely, but it was much better than leaving a gaping hole.

Adora was waiting for her in a small alcove a dozen paces into the passage, looking uncertain. ‘Listen, wait, I should tell you, I’ve been, um, struggling with She-Ra. In the cell. I had to fight my way out the hard way.’

Catra froze. ‘Like—with Prime? In the Heart?’

‘No, no.’ Adora shook her head, as if words weren’t enough. ‘Not like that. Well—maybe a little bit, but I’m good now. I—’ The hint of a blush coloured her cheeks. ‘Tero must have, uh, ransacked your room. She played the recording. Of us kissing. It… helped.’

‘She *what?*’

‘Yeah.’ Adora grinned. ‘I think it’s cute you kept it under your pillow, but are you sure that was the best decision? You know, strategically? I seem to recall Glimmer telling you to delete it—’

Catra’s ears folded back. ‘Shut up.’

‘I’m just saying, you know, aren’t you meant to be the master tactician—’

‘Shut *up,*’ Catra repeated, trying to keep the laughter from bubbling up. It wasn’t easy. It didn’t matter that she’d fucked up the plan. Not when Adora was here, unable to summon She-Ra, and acting like that was a minor inconvenience. Something to be dealt with later, when there was time. Not the defining fact of her life. Not a matter of life and death. ‘Maybe I wanted a reminder that you were mine. *Actually* mine.’

‘Aww! Wait until Bow hears about this.’

‘Adora, I *swear*—’

‘I get it,’ Adora said, more seriously. ‘You had the right idea. I wish I’d thought of it, too. Would’ve made things a whole lot easier.’ She cleared her throat. ‘Anyway, it didn’t matter, I hit Tero on the head with these nice hard handcuffs they gave me, and—’

‘Wait,’ Catra interrupted. ‘I have an idea. Can I…’ She gestured at Adora’s wrists.

Adora cocked her head in curiosity but complied, holding her cuffed wrists out for Catra to examine. Catra unsheathed her claws and severed first the chain, then, more carefully, each of the individual cuffs. Adora’s breath caught in her throat.

‘You okay there?’ Catra said, running a thumb over the inside of Adora’s wrist.

‘Sometimes I forget how sharp your claws are,’ Adora mumbled. ‘It’s, um, impressive.’

‘*Impressive*.’ Catra grinned. ‘Right.’ She undid the other cuffs, too, the ones she’d claimed would shut down She-Ra’s powers. ‘There. Try now. But, uh, maybe not all the way. These fucking walls are too translucent, they’d see the light from three rooms away.’

‘Catra, you know as well as I do that those cuffs didn’t do anything.’

‘I know. Try anyway.’

Adora gave her a dubious look, but she did as instructed. The light coalesced around her hand almost immediately, elongating into the familiar shape of She-Ra’s sword. A moment before it became tangible, Adora closed her hand into a fist, and it vanished.

‘I don’t get it,’ she whispered. ‘Why would that have mattered?’

Catra forgot, sometimes, that for all they'd been through, for all the horrors of their childhood, Adora still operated mostly by instinct. She hadn't spent as long as Catra had, curled up late at night, cataloguing the ways the world hated her. She hadn't learnt to unlearn that habit. To develop new, better habits. To know how her own brain worked.

Catra smiled. Cupped Adora's face in her hands, drew her close enough to kiss. 'Sometimes you get mixed up,' she murmured. 'Sometimes you believe something so hard, even knowing it's not true isn't enough. Sometimes what you really need is someone to show you.'

Adora relaxed into the touch. Her lips brushed against Catra's in the lightest kiss. Catra's pulse jumped and before she quite knew what she was doing, she'd pushed Adora back against the wall of their alcove, one hand still on Adora's face, the other on her hip, and kissed her like she'd imagined kissing her for days, long and hard and utterly unconcerned with the possibility of being caught, because that didn't matter anymore; because the plan was *over*, Adora was no one's captive, and whoever thought otherwise was in for a rude awakening.

*

Adora took a moment to catch her breath after the kiss. Her heart was racing. Catra's hand was still tangled in her hair, and when it left it took the last of Adora's uncertainty with it.

'Are they gone?' Adora said, after several long seconds in which she struggled to remember where they were and what was happening.

'Is who gone?'

'Whoever we were hiding from.'

Catra's smile turned playful. 'What, I need an excuse to kiss you now?'

‘*No*, but’—Catra ran her tail up the outside of her thigh, resulting in a shiver and a reflexive *‘Catra!’*—‘we’re being *stealthy*. Who knows how many people know about this tunnel!’

‘Mm,’ Catra said, and did the tail thing again. ‘A second ago you thought we were hiding, so I’m pretty sure this counts as stealth.’

‘Catra, seriously—’ The grin on Catra’s face was so infuriating, Adora undermined her own sternness by leaning down and kissing it. ‘We should get out of here.’

‘We should,’ Catra acknowledged. ‘The easy way or the hard way?’

‘What’s the easy way?’

‘I *think* this passage ends down at the bottom of the building, where they have some of those floating house-transport things tied up. I figure we steal one and head back to the city.’

‘See, this is a good plan. Straightforward. Doesn’t require us to grapple with emotions that, who knew, haven’t actually disappeared just because we’re together now.’

The words came so easily, Adora didn’t even stop to consider how they might sound; but Catra only smiled and that, really, was the thing. The tensions of their past were still there, woven into the complex tapestry of shared history between them; but so were ways of dealing with them. Every day they spent together wove new threads, clean threads. Every day, the clean made up a greater fraction of the whole. One day it would be a majority.

Until then, Adora said, ‘Lead the way.’

*

There were two transports waiting for them at the end of the passage, primed for the stealing, and the only thing standing in the way was Boss and every last one of her lackeys. Four dozen, Adora estimated. At least.

‘So much for the easy way,’ Catra said. Her ears twitched. ‘Bet I can take more of them.’

Adora grinned. ‘Bet you can’t.’

‘That’s what I *said*, Adora, it’s the same bet—’

‘*You!*’ Boss roared across the docking platform. Tero stood behind her looking, if Adora was any judge, more than a little sheepish.

‘Oh, right,’ Catra said. ‘Her.’

‘If you think I’m about to let you get away with this—’

Catra was already reaching for her whip, but Adora held up a hand to stop her. ‘Hold on,’ she said, then raised her voice. ‘We don’t want to hurt you! I don’t know why you hate me and my friends, but—’

‘I am the inheritor to Horde Prime’s power!’ Boss muscled her way to the front of her entourage, whole body rippling with rage and the confidence of blind arrogance. ‘What was his shall be mine, and I will not let you stand in my way, *She-Ra*—’

‘All right, never mind,’ Adora said, and held her right arm out. There was no uncertainty when she said the words, no hesitation when the golden light of She-Ra flowed through her, nothing but the magic doing what it was supposed to do, and when the transformation was complete, it was the assorted ruffians at Boss’ side who looked outnumbered. Adora let herself bask for a moment, partly because she enjoyed it and partly to keep the attention on her while Catra snuck off to the side. The building rumbled beneath her as if even it was scared of her.

Then she braced herself for the onslaught as four dozen people charged her across the docking pad. She raised her sword and brought it across her body in a horizontal slash, the ensuing sheet of light forcing the first wave of attackers back. Adora was dimly aware of the red flash of Catra’s whip cutting a swathe through the ranks bringing up the rear and she raised her sword again—

At which point the building abruptly ceased to float.

*

Tero came to with soft grass beneath her back and a bruise the size of her entire body spreading across her skin. Her ears rang, not with noise, but with the silence that came after: the silence of a building utterly destroyed, its remains settling on the surface of Charobia like a parachute drifting down from the sky.

The ringing resolved into conversation.

'That was interesting.' Catra's voice, dry as dust. 'I've never had to surf a building falling from the sky before.'

'You could have let me carry you.'

'Adora, you *jumped*.'

'It was fine! Nothing She-Ra couldn't handle.'

'Not the point. If I'm going to fall half a mile out of the sky, I'm going to do it with style.' Catra's voice was growing louder. Tero tensed, ready to spring into action, and only then noticed her left leg was pinned beneath something that used to be a chair. 'You think She-Ra made the building fall down?'

'I… think it's possible. I didn't make the connection until just now, but whenever I tried to transform, there'd be, like… the lights would stop working. Stuff like that. Maybe '

'If She-Ra interferes with the stuff holding their buildings up, I kind of get why the Charobians don't want anything to do with her.'

'What, you're saying there *isn't* an evil conspiracy, and we just spent a week infiltrating the most boring criminal gang in the universe for no reason?'

'We learnt something about ourselves! Isn't that enough, Adora?'

‘You sound like Perfuma.’

‘I do not—no! Take that back!’

How had Tero ever believed Catra was a ruthless bounty hunter? This was ridiculous. She pushed against the obstruction on her leg, wriggling awkwardly until her foot was free, took a moment to breathe—Catra was nearly on top of her; Tero could hear her laughing at another of She-Ra’s jokes—all she had to do was time her strike—

Tero lunged out of the rubble, one fist raised in a blow that would have felled Boss herself. If she’d had the time, she’d have been proud of her form. Flawless execution. Full marks.

She did not have time. Catra—who by all rights should never have seen Tero coming, who was facing away, whose ears nevertheless twitched in Tero’s direction—pivoted on one foot, deflected Tero’s punch, and—

Did nothing.

‘Hey, Adora,’ Catra called over her shoulder. ‘This one’s awake.’

Tero’s heart beat wildly. What was happening? She took another swing, more out of reflex than anything else. Catra caught her wrist, twisted under Tero’s arm, pinned it to the side of her body. A moment later she let go.

‘Listen, kid—’

Catra sidestepped Tero’s charge, sending her sprawling. She was dimly aware that She-Ra had rounded the corner, was staring down at Tero prone in the dirt. Dry grass pricked her neck. Catra’s footsteps crunched behind her. Tero rolled onto her back, braced herself.

Catra squatted next to Tero, balancing on the balls of her feet so easily it was as if she was made of stone. Tero swallowed past a mouthful of dust.

‘I said *listen*. I’m only going to say this once.’ Catra sighed. ‘I’ve been where you are. You know that? I guess not—you lot clearly have no idea what went down on Etheria. Anyway—I’ve done it all. World domination. Conquest. The whole deal.’ She-Ra stepped up to Catra’s side, one hand finding Catra’s shoulder as if by instinct. One of Catra’s ears twitched. ‘It will never make you happy,’ Catra said softly. ‘I don’t know what your story is. I don’t care. But this isn’t it. Find something else to do with your life.’

‘You—’ Tero spat onto the ground between them. ‘You expect me to—’

Catra stood. ‘I don’t care,’ she repeated. ‘It really, *really* doesn’t matter to me what you do. I’m never going to see you again. So take my advice or don’t. But this?’ She gestured at the collapsed building, at Tero’s comrades unconscious in the wreckage. ‘This is over.’

Catra’s eyes pierced through the haze and found hers. Tero tried to think of something to say. What would Boss say?

‘All right. I’m done. C’mon, Adora, we should get going. It’s a long way back on foot.’

Tero watched them leave, together; and slumped back onto the ground, alone; and never saw Catra again.

*

They made camp three hours later, in the shadow of a thicket of trees. On Etheria it would have been a respectable size; on Charobia it was dwarfed by the giant mushroom caps overhead. The sun was setting, washing the landscape in an even richer shade of bronze, highlighting the odd flash of purple or pink that might have been a rock or a plant or an animal hiding in the sea of grass.

‘No wonder the Charobians built up there,’ Catra muttered. ‘Who knows what’s hiding in the grass?’

‘I think we can handle it,’ Adora said. She was distracted by the pile of twigs in front of her, which she was attempting to light. ‘Remember the Northern Reach? We dealt with those things just fine.’

Catra snorted. ‘Interesting use of “we”. Also “dealt with”.’ Adora didn’t reply, too caught up in blowing gently on an ember Catra was pretty sure didn’t exist. ‘You good there? Need some help?’

‘I know what I'm doing! Gimme a minute.’

‘Where’d you learn to start a fire, anyway?’

‘Horde survival training.’

‘*Ugh.* Now you sound like Scorpia.’

A small flame licked around Adora’s pile of twigs. ‘Ha!’ she shouted, too vigorously. The fire went out. ‘*Fuck.*’

‘Here, let me.’

‘You *skipped* survival training, Catra—’

Catra unhooked the whip from her belt and thumbed it on. The glow cast a harsh red light on the scene, and the twigs burst into flame the moment it came in contact with them. She smirked at Adora, who looked like she couldn't decide whether to blush or tell Catra off, and reached around her to retrieve one of the larger branches Adora had painstakingly collected. She took her time, pressing her body casually against Adora’s back, and by the time she added the branch to their fire, the blush had thoroughly won out.

‘So,’ Catra said once the fire was crackling away and the sun was shedding the last of its purple glow across their campsite. ‘You wanna talk about what happened? With She-Ra?’

Adora groaned. ‘It’s… stupid.’

Catra poked her shoulder. ‘No, it’s not.’

‘You know how She-Ra is tied to, um, certainty? About my feelings. About why I’m doing stuff. Like in the Heart, where the key was, you know, finally feeling certain about you.’

Catra twitched her tail around Adora's waist. ‘How could I forget?’

‘Well… I wasn’t. Certain. This time.’

‘Because of me? Bounty hunter me, I mean?’

‘No! Well, yes. But… it’s not your fault. You were fantastic, I was just… stupid. It’s like, I saw the way you were acting and the way you treated me and I... I was prepared to feel insecure, you know? To remind myself that you still loved me. But I didn’t have to, because I still… I still liked *you*, so much, I was still *attracted* to you, and I thought… what if there’s something wrong with me, because that’s, um, that’s how I felt during the war, too, you know, you’d do the’—Adora fluttered her hands in an entirely unenlightening manner—‘mean flirty thing and I’d *like* it, and so what if I like you for the wrong reasons, and… ugh. I don’t know, it sounds stupid now.’

‘Adora?’ Catra couldn’t help the spike of anxiety she felt as the words spilled out into the small space between them, but she kept it off her face. She knew how to handle unwanted feelings. At long, long last, they'd lost their power over her. ‘Think about the war. Think about me. Forget the fun bits, dancing together and so on. Think about the times I—hurt you. Directly. Did you like *those*?’

‘I—no, of course not.’

‘So is it maybe possible that you weren’t attracted to me being—*evil*, for lack of a better word, you were just attracted to, you know, *me*?’

Adora buried her face in Catra's shoulder. ‘No fair,’ she said, muffled. ‘It sounds so obvious when you say it.’

‘Advantage of spending my formative years as an evil mastermind obsessing over how you felt about me.’ Catra felt the warmth of Adora’s laugh on her skin, ran her fingers through Adora’s hair. ‘And—I’m sorry. I thought maybe if I flirted with you it would be reassuring, you know? Even if it was like… that. Come to think of it, I think that’s how, whatsherface, the sidekick—’

‘Tero?’

‘Ooh, first name terms, huh?’

‘*Whatever*.’

‘I think that’s how she caught on. She figured out I was trying to reassure you, and that’s why she searched my room. More observant than I gave her credit for.’

‘Well. I’m glad you were doing it. Even if it went over my head.’

‘Yeah. Me too.’

‘Hey.’ Adora fidgeted. Not insecure, Catra thought, but embarrassed. ‘Thanks. For listening. I *know* the way I was feeling wasn’t real, but…’

‘Sometimes that’s not enough.’

‘Promise you don’t think I’m weird?’

‘I don’t think you’re weird.’

‘Okay. Okay. Good.’

Adora curled up closer, face tilted towards Catra, firelight sparkling in her eyes. Catra swallowed. Adora’s fingers traced the leather of her clothing, the swathes of skin left bare by it, and came to rest on the pommel of Catra's whip. When her gaze met Catra's, there was more fire in her eyes than a mere reflection could account for.

‘Huh,’ Catra whispered. ‘Sparkles was right. I *did* do a number on you.’

Adora groaned.

‘You know, if you want me to dress up like this more often—’

‘Catra…’

‘I’m just saying, I can mean-flirt with you *whenever* you want—’

‘*Please* stop.’

‘Really?’

Adora bit her lip. ‘… No.’

Catra leaned down, brushed her lips along the shell of Adora’s ear. ‘Yeah,’ she breathed. ‘I didn’t think so.’

The last of the sun dipped below the horizon, casting Adora’s features in the sharp, flickering angles of the campfire. Catra cupped her face, the leather of her glove and the points of her claws against the softness of Adora’s cheek. She could practically see the flutter of Adora’s heartbeat at her throat.

Out in the grass, something began to howl, many-voiced and chittering like a pack of cockroaches who thought they were wolves. Adora jerked upright, face flushed with surprise and embarrassment.

‘I hate to say it,’ Adora said. ‘But do we maybe want to...’

‘Not get eaten in our sleep?’

‘... Yeah.’

‘I'll take first watch.’

‘Okay.’ Adora nodded, once. ‘Okay. But—’

Catra grinned, drew out her next word: ‘But?’

‘But...’ Adora reached for Catra’s belt, pulled her closer by it, and kissed her, brief and full of heat. ‘Raincheck?’

Chapter End Notes

halfway through this fic I was like, I think this villain is too interesting to just drop a building on her, but oh well :D

you may note there is a fair amount of plot left unresolved - that's because this fic was initially outlined to be like twice as long but I simply didn't have that much time. I thought instead I'd write the full catradora arc and leave myself open to resolve the rest if I felt like it later. ❤ I hope you enjoyed it nonetheless!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!